Doom in the Red Wastes



A 4th-level ShadowDark adventure by Kelsey Dionne

Doom in the Red Wastes





Writing, Design, Dungeon Cartography, Layout

Kelsey Dionne.

Art

Trade dress by Brandish Gilhelm. **Cover** by Matt Morrow. **Art** by Yuri Perkowski-Domingos pgs. 9 and 10.

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ShadowDark



Overview

A brutal sandstorm drives the characters to seek shelter in a deserted cave. But when they awaken, they find themselves inside a hellish **pyramid** filled with sinister foes and sorcerous treasure!

Can they find their way out, or will they be trapped inside forever?

INHABITANTS

A powerful **rakshasa** sorcerer named **Barghavera** built this pyramid to help expand his magical collection of "exotic creatures" and show them off to his devilish friends in fights to the death.

His **brass automatons** do the grunt work of monitoring and collecting new live specimens.

THE PYRAMID

The red **floor** and **walls** are made of an ironlike substance peppered with dents and scratches. The air is hot and hazy, difficult to breathe.

A muted, industrial **hum** constantly chugs along from somewhere; the source of it is impossible to place.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

d4	Details
1	An **ankheg** trying (fruitlessly) to burrow through the floor
2	The **shadow** of one of the rakshasa's defeated creatures
3	A damaged **brass automaton** walking endlessly into a wall
4	A **brass automaton** giving a **cubi** guest a facility tour

FLOORS

Floor 1: Intake. Creatures who rest in a magically trapped desert cave Barghavera created are teleported here to Area 1. There are no exits. **Brass automatons** watch unseen from Floor 2 and abduct notable creatures for their rakshasa overlord's "collection."

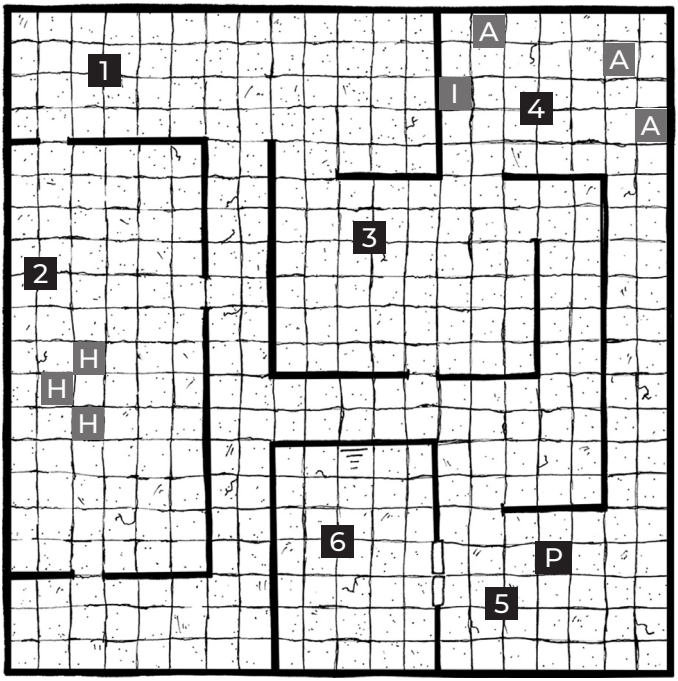
Floor 2: Fabrication. Here, the brass automatons create the **equipment** needed to capture creatures from Floor 1 and store them in magical glass bottles.

Floor 3: Quarters. The rakshasa hosts his friends here to watch his favorite bottled creatures battle in an extradimensional **arena.**

Floor 1: Intake

Danger: Risky
Light: Dark
Doors: Locked (DC 20)

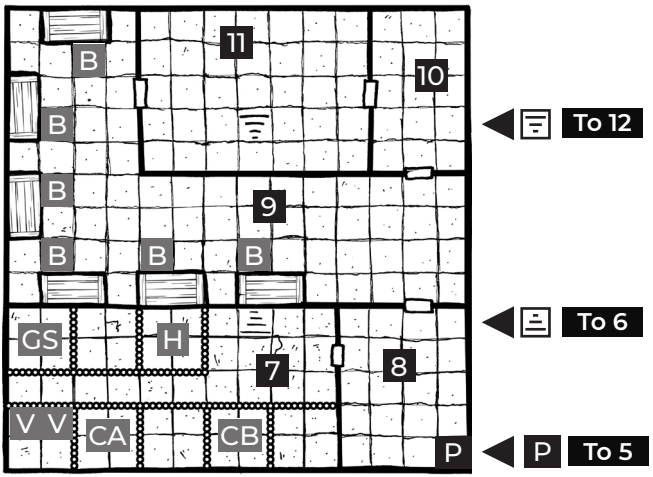
P
Ceiling Panel



Floor 2: Fabrication

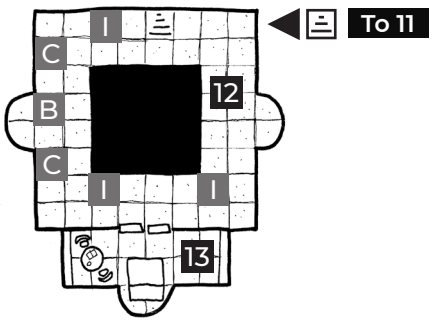
Danger: Unsafe
Light: Lit
Doors: Unlocked (except cells in Area 7, DC 20)

P
Floor Panel



Floor 3: Quarters

Danger: Unsafe
Light: Lit
Doors: Unlocked



Floor 1: Intake

Danger Level. Risky. Check for an encounter every **2** crawling rounds.

Light. Total darkness.

1. Awakening Room. Desolate, dark. Stifling heat and a distant, mechanical thrum. Grit and grime crunches underfoot on the red metal floors.

2. Humanoid Camp. Three hollow-eyed, filthy humans (as **guards**) crouch around a weak campfire and stare into the flames. They leap up in fear at noise, grabbing weapons.

- **Humans.** Carina, Marvis, Bolrin. Explorers; woke up here a week ago. Starving, terrified. They hide from the **ankhegs** (Area 4) who killed and dragged away their friend Tirius two days ago. They've caught glimpses of a "**brass man**" wandering around who ignores their pleas for help.

3. Crossroads. Battered hall littered with **junk** (shattered weapons, clothes, bones). The reek of a recently dead **mountain lion** sours the air (it's covered in acid burns). In the debris is a *Potion of Healing* and a broken jade hair comb (60 gp).

4. Ankheg Nest. Shadowy, horse-sized cockroaches (**ankhegs**) scuttle around in abrupt bursts. They're busy chewing bones into **hive pulp** to glob onto the walls. The sandy, pocked hive material covers all surfaces. A muffled **voice** screeches from somewhere in the room.

- **Voice.** Smizzik, an indignant **imp**, is trapped inside a drying lump of hive pulp. He's a guest of Barghavera but teleported to the wrong floor. He "came with my mistress to see a battle" (a cubi).

5. Scrap Heap. A mangled pile of **brass scrap** lies on the floor (destroyed **brass automaton**). A shattered glass bottle lies nearby with a label that says "lion." (silver stopper worth 20 gp).

- **Ceiling Panel.** Faint white light peeks around a loose ceiling panel 10' up. It leads to Area 8.

6. Locked Room. Brass **double doors**. Dented, smeared with filth. Locked (STR/DEX DC 20). Inside, spotlessly clean. Smells of bleach. **Disks** on ceiling glow a harsh white. The occasional animalistic roar echoes down **stairs**.

Floor 2: Fabrication

Danger Level. Unsafe. Check for an encounter every **3** crawling rounds.

Light. Blindingly lit by sterile, white ceiling domes (break if removed).

7. Holding Cells. Agitated **desert creatures** pace around in locked cages inside this room. The thick bars cannot be bent (DEX DC 20 to pick locks). Odor of filth just underneath the sterile bleach smell.

- **Creatures.** Canyon ape (tan, shaggy **gorilla**), **cave brute** (blinded by locked steel helm), **hippogriff**, **giant scorpion**, two **velociraptors**.

8. Zookeeper's Room. Animal control **tools** hung neatly on wall pegs (leashes, blinder helms, muzzles, manacles, collars, nets). Two barrels of fresh water and one of powder that says "Protein Slop. Add Water." **Sign** over west door: "Days since last fatal incident: 6."

- **Zookeeper.** 1:4 chance each round a whistling **brass automaton** enters from Area 9 carrying steel feeding bowls.
- **Floor Panel.** Loose; can be lifted. Drops into Area 5.

9. Work Room. Six industrious **brass automatons** bustle around work tables creating *Magic Bottles* or spying on "potential specimens" in Areas 1-6 with their Scry Sight. One has the **key** to the doors in Area 6. There are two completed *Magic Bottles* sitting on a work table.

- ***Magic Bottle.*** Simple glass bottles with silver stoppers. Opening an empty bottle toward a creature within close shrinks the creature and pulls it inside the bottle (DC 15 STR to resist each round). A creature inside does not age or need to eat/drink. When the bottle breaks, the creature is set free.

10. Storage Room. Shelves stuffed with pipes and tubes, tools, buckets, mops, cleaning solution, and five half-assembled brass automatons.

11. Creature Collection. Dark. Red-lit **shelves** house rows upon rows of labeled *Magic Bottles* with tiny, seething creatures inside (one of each creature from *Shadowdark RPG* of level 10 or less). A blue-lit shelf that says "Champions" displays a dozen of the strongest creatures.

Floor 3: Quarters

Danger Level. Unsafe. Check for an encounter every **3** crawling rounds.

Light. Lit by torches in wall sconces.

12. Battle Arena. Two tittering **cubi** and their three **imp** attendants loll on plush chairs with Barghavera (**rakshasa**), a fat panther-man with striking yellow eyes and silk robes. They sip glass flutes of fizzy wine. An extradimensional **pit** dominates the floor (30' deep, 60' wide at the bottom). A lever extends retractable steel bars over the opening.

- **Fight.** If a fight breaks out, the scandalized cubi and their imps teleport back to hell.
- **Bottles.** Barghavera has two *Magic Bottles* in his pocket that he planned to throw into the pit. One holds a **wyvern** and the other a silver-haired **gorilla**. He throws them at the ground near the PCs as a distraction and tries to escape to Area 13 to use the *Snow Globe*.
  - ▸ **Enemies.** The wyvern and gorilla spend 2 rounds attacking each other before turning on the PCs.

13. Apartments. Double doors open into a rich bedroom with red silk furnishings and gold accents. Books and trinkets line the wall shelves. A bay **window** looks out into a bleak desert canyon (where the characters originated).

- **Treasure.** The bookshelves hold the ***Tome of Hadebe*** (Shadowdark RPG pg. 319, spell scrolls of *burning hands*, *fireball*, *prismatic orb*), a ***Potion of Forgetfulness*** (Shadowdark RPG pg. 310, imbiber forgets one memory you choose), a hissing **cat dipped in gold** (200 gp), a faceted **ruby** carved to look like a cat eye (150 gp), and a tiny **snow globe** (below).
  - ▸ ***Snow Globe.*** Depicts a twisted, black tower perched over a lava-filled ravine. If shaken, it teleports the person holding it to Barghavera's keep in the lower reaches of hell.

Monsters

ANKHEG

Horse-sized, rust-brown insects. They burrow vast, underground warrens into the bedrock.

AC 14, **HP** 14, **ATK** 1 bite +4 (1d6) or 1 acid spray (near) +4 (2d6), **MV** near (burrow), **S** +2, **D** +2, **C** +1, **I** -2, **W** +1, **Ch** -2, **AL** N, **LV** 3

BRASS AUTOMATON

Well-mannered brass robots in the shape of human men. Loyal workers. Ruthlessly uncaring.

AC 12, **HP** 11, **ATK** 1 punch +2 (1d6), **MV** near, **S** +2, **D** +0, **C** +2, **I** +0, **W** +0, **Ch** -1, **AL** N, **LV** 2

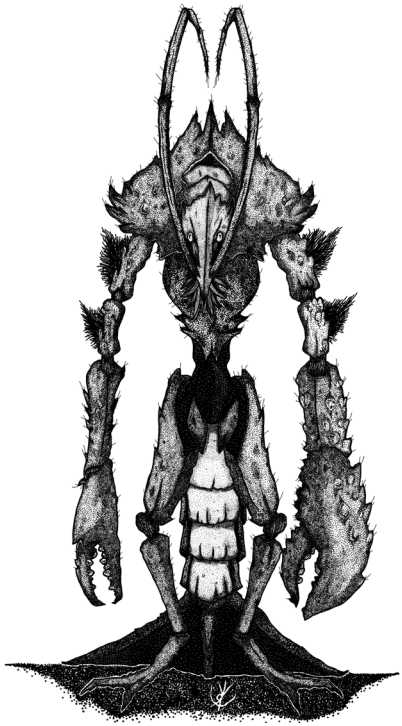
Scry Sight. Can see any known location from afar within a mile.

CAVE BRUTE

A hulking, insectoid beast with long mandibles, four eyes, and thick arms covered in bristles.

AC 14, **HP** 28, **ATK** 2 claw +5 (1d8) and 1 mandible +5 (1d10), **MV** near (burrow), **S** +4, **D** +1, **C** +1, **I** -3, **W** +1, **Ch** -3, **AL** N, **LV** 6

Bewilder. Creatures within near that see the cave brute's eyes, DC 12 CHA at start of their turn or dazed and no action.



CUBI

Entrancing humanoids with bat wings and devilish charm.

AC 14, **HP** 29, **ATK** 1 kiss +4 (1d6 + drain) or 1 charm, **MV** near (fly), **S** +2, **D** +4, **C** +2, **I** +3, **W** +2, **Ch** +5, **AL** C, **LV** 6

Change Shape. In place of attacks, transform into any similarly-sized humanoid.

Charm. One humanoid in near DC 15 CHA or bewitched by cubi for 1d6 hours.

Drain. The target takes 1d6 WIS damage. A target reduced to 0 WIS this way swears its soul to an archdevil.

GORILLA

Mighty, jungle-dwelling apes.

AC 12, **HP** 20, **ATK** 2 rend +5 (2d6), **MV** near (climb), **S** +4, **D** +2, **C** +2, **I** -1, **W** +1, **Ch** -1, **AL** N, **LV** 4

GUARD

A sentry equipped with sturdy weapons and armor.

AC 15 (chainmail + shield), **HP** 4, **ATK** 1 spear (close/near) +1 (1d6) or 1 longsword +1 (1d8), **MV** near, **S** +1, **D** +0, **C** +0, **I** +0, **W** +1, **Ch** +0, **AL** L, **LV** 1

HIPPOGRIFF

Fierce, winged creatures with the lower body of a horse and upper body of a giant eagle.

AC 13, **HP** 14, **ATK** 2 rend +3 (1d8), **MV** double near (fly), **S** +3, **D** +3, **C** +1, **I** -3, **W** +1, **Ch** -2, **AL** N, **LV** 3

IMP

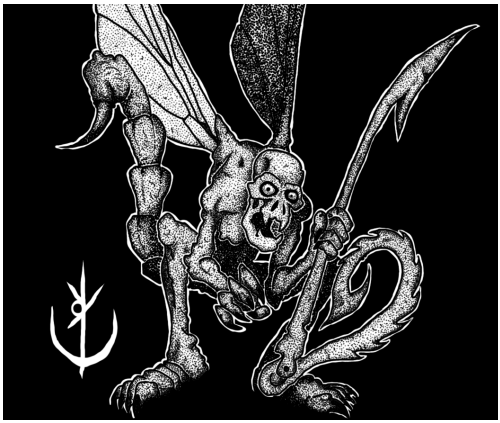
Cat-sized, red devils with oversized wings and tail, tiny horns, and cowardly demeanors.

AC 13, **HP** 9, **ATK** 1 stinger +3 (1d4 + poison), **MV** near (fly), **S** -2, **D** +3, **C** +0, **I** +1, **W** +0, **Ch** +2, **AL** C, **LV** 2

Impervious. Fire immune.

Contract. Can grant mighty boons and patronage on behalf of an archdevil in exchange for a sworn soul. ADV on related Charisma checks.

Poison. DC 12 CON or fitful sleep for 1d4 hours.



RAKSHASA

Demonic illusionists whose true form is of a humanlike great cat with backwards hands.

AC 16, **HP** 39, **ATK** 2 claw +6 (1d8), **MV** near, **S** +1, **D** +3, **C** +3, **I** +3, **W** +3, **Ch** +4, **AL** C, **LV** 8

Impervious. Only damaged by magical sources. Immune to hostile spells of 3rd tier or lower.

Mesmerism. Can read the minds of all creatures within near. Can instantly take on the illusory appearance of any humanoid.

Weakness. A crossbow bolt under the effects of the *holy weapon* spell kills the rakshasa.

SCORPION, GIANT

Chitin-plated scorpions as big as camels.

AC 14, **HP** 13, **ATK** 1 claw +2 (1d6 + grab) and 1 sting +2 (1d4 + poison), **MV** near (climb), **S** +2, **D** +2, **C** +0, **I** -4, **W** +0, **Ch** -4, **AL** N, **LV** 3

Grab. DC 12 STR or target held. DC 12 STR on turn to break free.

Poison. DC 12 CON or go to 0 HP.

SHADOW

Flitting, sentient shadows in the vague shape of a human.

AC 12, **HP** 15, **ATK** 2 touch +2 (1d4 + drain), **MV** near (fly), **S** -4, **D** +2, **C** +2, **I** -2, **W** +0, **Ch** -1, **AL** C, **LV** 3

Drain. Target takes 1 STR damage. At 0 STR, target dies and becomes a shadow.

VELOCIRAPTOR

Fast, turkey-sized raptors with vicious toe claws. Pack hunters.

AC 13, **HP** 10, **ATK** 1 claw +3 (1d6), **MV** double near, **S** -1, **D** +3, **C** +1, **I** -2, **W** +1, **Ch** -3, **AL** N, **LV** 2

Clever. +1d4 damage when attacking with surprise.

WYVERN

Dragon-cousins with a large tail stinger, mottled lizard skin, and leathery wings.

AC 15, **HP** 37, **ATK** 2 rend +6 (1d8) and 1 stinger +6 (1d6 + poison), **MV** double near (fly), **S** +4, **D** +2, **C** +1, **I** -3, **W** +1, **Ch** -3, **AL** N, **LV** 8

Poison. DC 15 CON or take 2d10 damage.